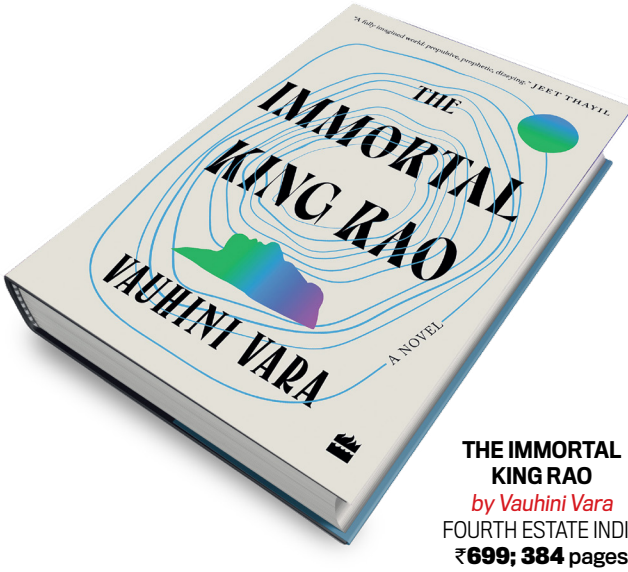
POWER MADE DYNAMIC



Speculative fiction meets Andhra social history in VAUHINI VARA's debut novel



THE IMMORTAL KING RAO
by Vauhini Vara
FOURTH ESTATE INDIA
₹699; 384 pages

Vauhini Vara's debut novel, *The Immortal King Rao*, is many things: a generational family saga, an immigrant and coming-of-age novel, a meditation on the promise and peril of technology, a critique of corporate power, and an ambiguous speculative dystopia. The novel follows the intertwined biographies of King Rao—a Dalit child born in the village of Kothapalli, who rises to become the leader of the world's most powerful technology company, before an equally precipitous fall—and his daughter, Athena, who remembers her own life while being held in a prison cell on charges of murder. From their tangled and uneasy relationship, two stories emerge: a slice of life in an Andhra village in the 1960s, with its complicated caste and social hierarchies, and a near-future world in which nation-states have finally yielded to global corporations, government is conducted by algorithm, getting off the grid is an (arguably) futile act of rebellion, and the climate catastrophe draws ever closer. The connecting thread between the two is the ubiquity of power in our lives, the inequity with which it is wielded, and its impact upon those who suffer it.

Life in **KOTHAPALLI** is full of colour. And ties between its protagonists are vivid and, at times, disturbing

It is a novel of moments, and Vara's writing is at its strongest in crystallising moments in ways that activate all the senses. Life in Kothapalli is full of colour and movement, and the relationship between its protagonists is vivid, memorable, and at times, disturbing. Arresting turns of phrase render characters gorgeously real: "Grandfather Rao's neck, fleshy as a wattle" etches a picture in the mind that remains long after the reader has put the book down. And Vara's sensitivity to the power relations that shape our interactions with each other, and even the words we form—conditioned by gender, caste, race, age or even economic power—gives the novel's moments a deeper hue.

The novel's speculative elements are ambitious, and at times bewilderingly crowded. Readers familiar with SF will recognise the following mainstays of the genre: algorithmically-controlled social relations and ascriptions of value; experimental technology for memory transmission; multinational corporations governing the world; anarchist, "off-grid" communes; hive minds; and the weaponisation of a monopolised internet. One does end up wishing, however, that the novel had engaged in a deeper conversation with the rich genre tradition within which each of these elements is embedded. To take just one example, the moral and ethical dilemmas around speculative hive-mind technology have been ever-present in SF (a recent example being Arkady Martine's *A Desolation Called Peace*, published last year). In *The Immortal King Rao*, other than a nod towards the dangers of top-down experimental corporate-driven technology in general, these debates are noticeable by their absence.

Finally, it is by no means a didactic novel, but perhaps its most significant achievement—through its generations-spanning story—is the reminder that encrusted power relations can take different forms, but whether mediated by caste (as in Kothapalli of the 1960s) or algorithm (the near-future world), it is up to us to discover both the vocabulary and the material means of resistance. Read through that lens, *The Immortal King Rao* fits well within the history and tradition of speculative and science fiction. ■

—Gautam Bhatia